

The Timeline (2022-2026): A History of Manipulation

In *Zero Sum*, the news you read over the last four years was only the surface layer. Here is the true, hidden history of the 2020s, providing the backdrop and active plots for the game.

2022: The Eastern Conflict & The Proxy War

- **The Public Narrative:** A massive geopolitical crisis in Eastern Europe as a superpower invades its neighbor. Global sanctions are applied, and a proxy war begins.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** While the human toll is tragically real, the military-industrial complex treats the conflict as the ultimate live-fire testing ground. Faction 2 (Private Intelligence & Cyber Mercenaries) field-tests autonomous drone swarms and zero-click cyberweapons against national infrastructure. The war drags on intentionally because the weapons manufacturers and energy syndicates are making record profits.
- **Game Hook:** The players discover a "Valkyrie Group" (PMC) data center in London that is using the war as a cover to launder stolen Ukrainian and Russian gold into the London real estate market.

2022-2023: The Crypto Collapse & "Apex" Fall

- **The Public Narrative:** The cryptocurrency market crashes violently. Major exchanges like "Apex" (run by Simon Bank-Firth) collapse overnight, revealing massive fraud and billions in lost customer funds.

- **The Zero Sum Truth:** Faction 3 (High Finance & Dark Money) orchestrated the crash. Crypto was becoming too decentralized and hard to track. By imploding the biggest exchanges, they destroyed public trust in decentralized finance, paving the way for government-backed Central Bank Digital Currencies (CBDCs)—which allow the state to track every single transaction a citizen makes.
- **Game Hook:** The players acquire a cold wallet belonging to an Apex executive. It contains not just money, but the transaction ledgers proving which politicians were bribed to let the fraud happen.

2023: The Silicon Valley Bank Run

- **The Public Narrative:** A sudden, panic-driven bank run collapses major tech-focused banks within 48 hours, threatening the startup ecosystem.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** This was an algorithmic assassination. A coalition of mega-corporations used bot swarms on social media ("Chirp") and private WhatsApp groups to trigger the panic artificially. Their goal was to bankrupt specific AI and quantum computing startups so they could acquire their patents for pennies on the dollar.
- **Game Hook:** A paranoid tech founder hires the players to extract her from San Francisco. She has the server logs proving the bank run was manufactured, and the mega-corps have sent "The Auditor" to silence her.

2023-2024: The AI Explosion

- **The Public Narrative:** Generative AI (like ChatGPT, Midjourney) bursts into the public sphere, revolutionizing work and causing mass panic about job losses and deepfakes.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** The AI was released prematurely on purpose by the Surveillance State. They realized whistleblowers were leaking too many authentic documents. By flooding the internet with AI-generated text, audio, and video, they created

the "Zero-Trust Era." Now, when a real whistleblower leaks a video of a war crime or corruption, the state simply claims it is an "AI Deepfake," and the exhausted public believes it.

- **Game Hook:** The players must find a way to verify a highly sensitive piece of evidence in a world where digital proof no longer holds up in court. They have to secure the *physical* hard drive from a heavily guarded Ashburn data center.

2024: The Global Elections & The Polarization Engine

- **The Public Narrative:** Massive, highly polarized elections occur across the US, UK, and EU. Unprecedented toxicity, riots, and political violence follow.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** "Aegis Analytics" (Faction 2) perfected their psychological profiling algorithm. They realized that angry, terrified citizens are highly predictable consumers and voters. They intentionally stoked the polarization using deepfakes and micro-targeted rage-bait. Neither side was meant to win decisively; the goal was a perfectly deadlocked, paralyzed government that cannot pass regulations against corporate monopolies.
- **Game Hook:** The players intercept an Aegis Analytics whistleblower. If they can publish the source code of the "Polarization Engine," they can prove the elections were psychologically rigged.

2025-2026: The Consolidation (The Present Day)

- **The Public Narrative:** The world settles into a grim new normal. High inflation, rampant gig-economy exploitation, and a massive consolidation of corporate power. "Chirp" becomes an "everything app" required for daily life.
- **The Zero Sum Truth:** The trap has snapped shut. Cash is almost entirely phased out, meaning every financial transaction

is monitored. To be a dissident is to be financially excommunicated. The players exist in the tiny, shrinking cracks of this system.